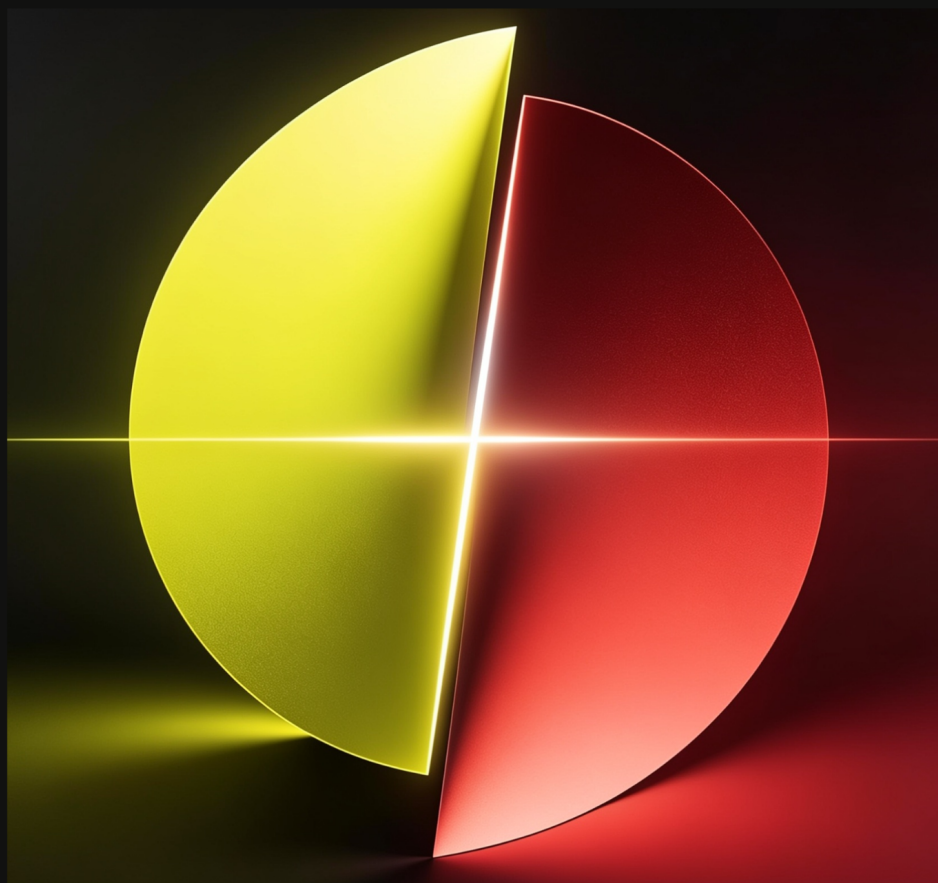


THE HIDDEN GAP



Solving the Human Alignment
Problem Behind Conflict,
Behaviour and Culture

Mark Buchan MSc.

PART 1:

What's Really Running the Show

All organisations and individuals have values, whether they have named them or not. They reveal themselves not in statements or slogans, but in patterns: what gets rewarded, what gets tolerated, what creates anxiety, and what disappears when pressure rises.

This first part of the book explores what is actually running the show beneath the surface — not to assign blame, but to establish the core premise of this work: why people clash, teams fracture, and change so often stalls.

Along the way, we will examine why behaviour looks the way it does, why values that sound right can still fail to guide action, and why the hidden gap between what is said and what is lived matters so much.

By the end of this section, you will have a clearer sense of why values — approached honestly and rigorously — matter more than most people realise, and why they hold the key to everything that follows.

Chapter 1 - When Values Compete

When Declared Values Meet Operating Reality

Most organisational values are not lies. They are unexamined wishes. They sound good, they feel right and almost everyone agrees with them — until the moment living by them actually costs something.

I was reminded of this in 2012 while working with a large UK insurance firm. You would recognise the brand. They were everywhere at the time: heavy television advertising, a strong public profile, all the outward signs of success.

Inside the organisation, though, the story was more complicated.

The invitation

I had been brought in to help improve collaboration across teams. That was it. No grand cultural mandate. No request to overhaul leadership identity or rewrite values statements. Just a fairly common brief: help teams work together better, communicate more effectively, and reduce some of the friction slowing things down.

At first, the work went well.

Teams were engaged. Conversations opened up. People started thinking differently about how they worked with one another — and about their role within the wider organisation. Word spread. The work expanded. People asked to attend the two-day course I was delivering.

From the outside, it looked promising.

But alongside the progress, I started to hear something else.

The unease

The same frustrations surfaced again and again across different teams: a reluctance to speak openly inside the organisation — though not in the training room, a sense that collaboration was encouraged in principle but constrained in practice, a feeling that some things could be said safely, and others could not.

And woven through these conversations was a phrase that kept cropping up, usually with a fair bit of dark humour attached:

"Man up, tool up."

I asked what it meant. It turned out to be the name of the leadership team, abbreviated to MUTU.

At that point, I had not met the leadership team. All of my work had been with the teams themselves. But in those sessions I started to hear a question that would follow me throughout much of my career:

"Have the leaders been on this course yet?"

The honest answer was no. I usually added, "Not yet."

Moving up the system

At first, I treated the phrase as a joke — the sort of internal shorthand every organisation develops. But as the work expanded into project and portfolio management, and as I began coaching more senior managers, it became clear that MUTU was doing more than raising a laugh.

It was carrying a message.

Strength meant endurance, maturity meant not pushing back. Discomfort was something to absorb quietly and compensate for by becoming more efficient, more resilient, more capable.

Some of the managers I worked with were open to exploring this. They engaged seriously with coaching, reflected on their behaviour, and made genuine shifts in how they behaved in practice.

And then, inevitably, word reached senior leaders.

There was genuine curiosity from leaders about the impact the work was having. I was invited into what were described as casual conversations. Some of those conversations developed into formal coaching contracts. For a while, it felt as though the work might finally be moving where it needed to go.

When the mirror appears

Eventually, I was invited to speak with the CEO.

The conversation was meant to cover progress, observations, and the possibility of extending the work further — perhaps even into collective coaching with the executive team.

During the conversation, I raised the subject of the executive team's name.

It had become clear to me that "Man up, tool up" was not neutral. It carried an expectation about how people were meant to behave, what emotions were acceptable, and how dissent was handled. It framed struggle as a personal shortcoming rather than a signal that something systemic might need attention.

The reaction was immediate.

His face flushed.

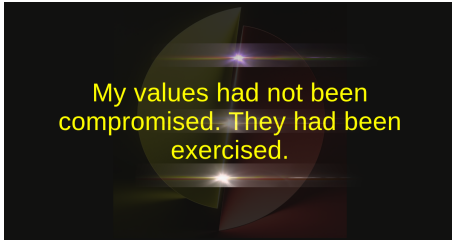
This was not the conversation he had expected to have. In that moment, two things happened inside me: one part wanted to retreat, to soften it, to find a way back to safer ground. Another part was quietly, almost guiltily, fascinated. That response told me something important.

The atmosphere shifted. It became clear, very quickly, that I was not delivering the report he had assumed was coming.

I was not there to accuse or blame anyone. I was holding up a mirror - but it did not land that way.

Endings

Shortly afterwards, my contract was not renewed. Up until then, it had been extended on a rolling basis without question. This time it ended politely, professionally, and without much follow-up.



I will not pretend I was not disappointed. I had invested in the work and cared about the people it affected. But what struck me afterwards was how quickly that disappointment passed.

My values had not been compromised. They had been exercised.

In the years since, I have stayed in touch with several people from that organisation. Later, I heard about dismissals and HR cases involving members of the senior leadership team. The issues had not disappeared, they had simply surfaced later, once the damage was harder to contain.

Looking back, the outcome feels almost inevitable.

Every leadership team I have worked with has placed words such as honesty, openness, and truth somewhere near the top of its declared values. Very few are prepared for what follows when those values begin to implicate them.

The things left unsaid in that organisation were not left unsaid because they were unimportant. They were left unsaid because naming them had consequences.

Over time, I have come to understand my role in these situations differently. I do not see myself as the cause of conflict. More often, I act as a kind of lightning rod — attracting the charge that already exists in a system under pressure, and grounding it before it does more damage elsewhere.

That role is not especially comfortable. It rarely comes with applause. But it is honest.

And it raises the question at the heart of this book:

What happens when the values we say we stand for are not the ones actually running the show?

What happens when declared values meet operating reality?

Next

In the next chapter, I will explore why that hidden gap matters so much — and why unclear or misaligned values create the very clashes, team fractures, and stalled change that so many organisations recognise but rarely name.

Dear Reader,

If this has resonated and if, like me, you may have sat in those meetings where everyone agreed and nothing changed, then the book will have even more to offer you. The book is out now on Amazon Kindle, with the paperback now also released: [Buy now on Amazon](#)

As a thank you for connecting on LinkedIn, use LINKEDIN25 for 25% off the direct edition at markbuchan.co.uk/book.

If you'd rather talk about specifics in your organisation, a free diagnostic conversation usually surfaces something useful. [Book a diagnostic conversation here](#).

And if you want to keep reading as the thinking evolves, From Our Trenches, my Substack, is where that happens: [Subscribe to my Substack here](#).

Again, my thanks for your time and support.

Warm regards,

Mark

Author of The Hidden Gap.